

Eryops

EH-ree-ops

- **When** 295 million years ago (Early Permian)
- **Fossil location** N. America
- **Habitat** Swamps of N. America and western Europe
- **Length** About 6 ft (1.8 m)

One of the largest land animals of its time, *Eryops* looked like a fat crocodile. It had a long snout (its name means “drawn-out face”), and



its huge, strong jaws were lined with sharp fangs. It couldn't chew and so would have flung its head up and backward, tossing prey further into its mouth just as crocodiles and alligators do today. *Eryops* had sturdy limbs but moved slowly on land because of its bulky body and short legs.



Acanthostega

ah-CAN-tho-STAY-gah

- **When** 365 million years ago (Late Devonian)
- **Fossil location** Greenland
- **Habitat** Northern rivers and swamps
- **Length** About 2 ft (0.6 m)

This is believed to have been the first tetrapod capable of briefly climbing out of water. It had lungs but also gills and is thought to have lived largely in shallow swamps. Unlike its fish relatives, *Acanthostega* had eight webbed digits on its forelimbs.

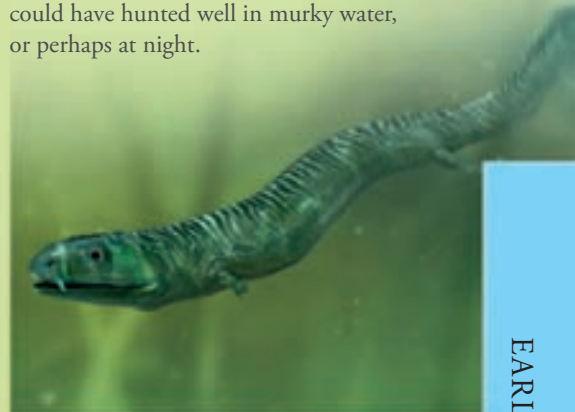


Crassigyrinus

CRASS-ee-jih-RYE-nuss

- **When** 350 million years ago (Early Carboniferous)
- **Fossil location** Scotland and USA
- **Habitat** Shallow waters of northern Europe
- **Length** About 5 ft (1.5 m)

This bizarre creature probably lived in water, since its tiny limbs would have made walking on land impossible. It was a large and powerful predator, with two rows of sharp teeth lining a huge mouth that it used to catch prey with a snapping motion. Large eyes suggest it could have hunted well in murky water, or perhaps at night.



EARLY VERTEBRATES



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Four limbs with wrist and elbow joints
- Distinct fingers and toes
- Eggs laid in water
- Fishlike larvae (babies)

When

Amphibians evolved from fish during the Devonian Period, 370–400 million years ago.